Reading List: Japanese Economic History

Mingyu Shu
shumingyu@foxmail.com

May 3, 2026

I. The Great Divergence & Historical National Accounting

I. The Great Divergence & National Accounting

1. Bassino, J.-P., Broadberry, S., Fukao, K., Gupta, B. & Takashima, M. (2019). "Japan and the Great Divergence, 730–1874." *EEH*, 72, 1–22.
   Link
2. Broadberry, S., Fukao, K. & Settsu, T. (2026). "How Did Japan Catch-Up with the West?" *AEHR*, 66(1), 3–32.
   Link
3. Sng, T.-H. & Moriguchi, C. (2014). "Asia's Little Divergence: State Capacity in China and Japan before 1850." *Journal of Economic Growth*, 19(4), 439–470.
   Link

I. The Great Divergence (cont.)

4. Koyama, M., Moriguchi, C. & Sng, T.-H. (2018). "Geopolitics and Asia's Little Divergence: State Building in China and Japan after 1850." *JEBO*, 155, 178–204.
   Link
5. Ko, C.Y., Koyama, M. & Sng, T.-H. (2018). "Unified China and Divided Europe." *International Economic Review*, 59(1), 285–327.
   Link
6. Fernández-Villaverde, J., Koyama, M., Lin, Y. & Sng, T.-H. (2023). "The Fractured-Land Hypothesis." *QJE*, 138(2), 1173–1231.
   Link

II. Trade & Comparative Advantage

II. Trade & Comparative Advantage

1. Bernhofen, D.M. & Brown, J.C. (2004). "A Direct Test of the Theory of Comparative Advantage: The Case of Japan." *JPE*, 112(1), 48–67.
   Link
2. Bernhofen, D.M. & Brown, J.C. (2005). "An Empirical Assessment of the Comparative Advantage Gains from Trade: Evidence from Japan." *AER*, 95(1), 208–225.
   Link
3. Bernhofen, D.M. & Brown, J.C. (2016). "Testing the General Validity of the Heckscher-Ohlin Theorem." *AEJ: Microeconomics*, 8(4), 54–90.
   Link

II. Trade & Comparative Advantage (cont.)

4. Davis, D.R. & Weinstein, D.E. (2002). "Bones, Bombs, and Break Points: The Geography of Economic Activity." *AER*, 92(5), 1269–1289.
   Link
5. Meissner, C.M. & Tang, J.P. (2018). "Upstart Industrialization and Exports: Evidence from Japan, 1880–1910." *JEH*, 78(4), 1068–1102.
   Link
6. Tang, J.P. (2011). "Technological Leadership and Late Development: Evidence from Meiji Japan, 1868–1912." *EHR*, 64(S1), 99–116.
   Link

III. Wages, Living Standards & the Industrious Revolution

III. Wages, Living Standards & the Industrious Revolution

1. Kumon, Y. (2022). "The Labor-Intensive Path: Wages, Incomes, and the Work Year in Japan, 1610–1890." *JEH*, 82(2), 469–506.
   Link
2. Allen, R.C., Bassino, J.-P., Ma, D., Moll-Murata, C. & van Zanden, J.L. (2011). "Wages, Prices, and Living Standards in China, 1738–1925: In Comparison with Europe, Japan, and India." *EHR*, 64(S1), 8–38.
   Link
3. Broadberry, S. & Gupta, B. (2006). "The Early Modern Great Divergence: Wages, Prices and Economic Development in Europe and Asia, 1500–1800." *EHR*, 59(1), 2–31.
   Link

III. Wages & Living Standards (cont.)

4. Saito, O. (2015). "Growth and Inequality in the Great and Little Divergence Debate: A Japanese Perspective." *EHR*, 68(2), 399–419.
   Link
5. Bassino, J.-P. (2006). "Inequality in Japan (1892–1941): Physical Stature, Income, and Health." *Economics & Human Biology*, 4(1), 62–88.
   Link
6. Bassino, J.-P. & Ma, D. (2006). "Japanese Unskilled Wages in International Perspective, 1741–1913." *Research in Economic History*, 24, 229–248.
   Link

IV. Institutions & State Capacity

IV. Institutions & State Capacity

1. Moriguchi, C. (2003). "Implicit Contracts, the Great Depression, and Institutional Change: A Comparative Analysis of U.S. and Japanese Employment Relations, 1920–1940." *JEH*, 63(3), 625–665.
   Link
2. Moriguchi, C. & Saez, E. (2008). "The Evolution of Income Concentration in Japan, 1886–2005: Evidence from Income Tax Statistics." *REStat*, 90(5), 713–734.
   Link
3. Sng, T.-H. (2014). "Size and Dynastic Decline: The Principal-Agent Problem in Late Imperial China, 1700–1850." *EEH*, 54, 107–127.
   Link

IV. Institutions & State Capacity (cont.)

4. Ma, D. & Rubin, J. (2019). "The Paradox of Power: Principal-Agent Problems and Administrative Capacity in Imperial China." *JCE*, 47(2), 277–294.
   Link
5. Hayashi, F. & Prescott, E.C. (2008). "The Depressing Effect of Agricultural Institutions on the Prewar Japanese Economy." *JPE*, 116(4), 573–632.
   Link
6. Okazaki, T. (2005). "The Role of the Merchant Coalition in Pre-modern Japanese Economic Development." *EEH*, 42(2), 184–201.
   Link

V. Finance, Banking & Credit

V. Finance, Banking & Credit

1. Basco, S. & Tang, J.P. (2020). "The Samurai Bond: Credit Supply, Market Access, and Structural Transformation in Pre-War Japan." *JEH*, 80(2), 417–454.
   Link
2. Miwa, Y. & Ramseyer, J.M. (2006). "Japanese Industrial Finance at the Close of the 19th Century: Trade Credit and Financial Intermediation." *EEH*, 43(1), 94–118.
   Link
3. Tang, J.P. (2013). "Financial Intermediation and Late Development in Meiji Japan, 1868 to 1912." *Financial History Review*, 20(2), 111–135.
   Link

V. Finance, Banking & Credit (cont.)

4. Mitchener, K.J. & Ohnuki, M. (2009). "Institutions, Competition, and Capital Market Integration in Japan." *JEH*, 69(1), 138–171.
   Link
5. Miwa, Y. & Ramseyer, J.M. (2002). "Banks and Economic Growth: Implication from Japanese History." *Journal of Law and Economics*, 45(1), 128–164.
   Link
6. Morck, R. & Nakamura, M. (2007). "Business Groups and the Big Push: Meiji Japan's Mass Privatization and Subsequent Growth." *Enterprise & Society*, 8(3), 543–601.
   Link

VI. Infrastructure & Structural Transformation

VI. Infrastructure & Structural Transformation

1. Tang, J.P. (2014). "Railroad Expansion and Industrialization: Evidence from Meiji Japan." *JEH*, 74(3), 863–886.
   Link
2. Tang, J.P. (2014). "Railroad Growth and Market Integration in Meiji Japan." *EEH*, 53, 39–65.
   Link
3. Braguinsky, S., Ohyama, A., Okazaki, T. & Syverson, C. (2015). "Acquisitions, Productivity, and Profitability: Evidence from the Japanese Cotton Spinning Industry." *AER*, 105(7), 2086–2119.
   Link

VI. Infrastructure & Structural Transformation (cont.)

4. Donaldson, D. (2018). "Railroads of the Raj: Estimating the Impact of Transportation Infrastructure." *AER*, 108(4–5), 899–934.
   Link
5. Tang, J.P. (2017). "The Engine and the Reaper: Industrialization and Mortality in Late Nineteenth Century Japan." *Journal of Health Economics*, 56, 145–162.
   Link
6. Fukao, K., Ma, D. & Yuan, T. (2006). "International Comparison in Historical Perspective: Reconstructing the 1934–36 Benchmark PPP for Japan, Korea, and Taiwan." *EEH*, 43(2), 280–308.
   Link

VII. Demography & Human Capital

VII. Demography & Human Capital

1. Drixler, F. (2016). "Hidden in Plain Sight: Stillbirths and Infanticides in Imperial Japan." *JEH*, 76(3), 651–696.
   Link
2. Moriguchi, C. & Saez, E. (2008). "The Evolution of Income Concentration in Japan, 1886–2005." *REStat*, 90(5), 713–734.
   Link
3. Saito, O. (2015). "Growth and Inequality in the Great and Little Divergence Debate: A Japanese Perspective." *EHR*, 68(2), 399–419.
   Link

VII. Demography & Human Capital (cont.)

4. Bassino, J.-P. (2006). "Inequality in Japan (1892–1941): Physical Stature, Income, and Health." *Economics & Human Biology*, 4(1), 62–88.
   Link
5. Ogasawara, K. (2024). "Consumption Smoothing in the Working-Class Households of Interwar Japan." *JEH*, 84(1), 111–148.
   Link
6. Narita, Y., Moriguchi, C. & Tanaka, M. (2024). "Meritocracy and Its Discontents: Long-run Effects of Repeated School Admission Reforms." *Working Paper*, Cowles Foundation.
   Link

VIII. Consumption & Household Economics

VIII. Consumption & Household Economics

1. Ogasawara, K. (2024). "Consumption Smoothing in the Working-Class Households of Interwar Japan." *JEH*, 84(1), 111–148.
   Link
2. James, J.A. & Suto, I. (2011). "Early Twentieth-Century Japanese Worker Saving: Precautionary Behaviour before a Social Safety Net." *Cliometrica*, 5(1), 1–25.
   Link
3. Inoue, T. (2021). "The Role of Pawnshops in Risk Coping in Early Twentieth-Century Japan." *Financial History Review*, 28(3), 1–25.
   Link

VIII. Consumption & Household Economics (cont.)

4. Schneider, E.B. & Ogasawara, K. (2018). "Disease and Child Growth in Industrializing Japan: Critical Windows and the Growth Pattern, 1917–39." *EEH*, 69, 64–80.
   Link
5. Francks, P. (2012). "Kimono Fashion: The Consumer and the Growth of the Textile Industry in Pre-War Japan." In *The Historical Consumer*.
   Link

IX. Colonial & Imperial Legacy

IX. Colonial & Imperial Legacy

1. Arimoto, Y. & Lee, C. (2021). "Domestic Industrialization under Colonization: Evidence from Korea, 1932–1940." *European Review of Economic History*, 25(2), 379–407.
   Link
2. Cha, M. (2023). "The Colonial Origins of Market Integration: Evidence from Korea under Japanese Rule." *Cliometrica*, 17(3), 421–455.
   Link
3. Fukao, K., Yue, T. & Yuan, T. (2006). "International Comparison in Historical Perspective: Reconstructing the 1934–36 Benchmark PPP for Japan, Korea, and Taiwan." *EEH*, 43(2), 280–308.
   Link

IX. Colonial & Imperial Legacy (cont.)

4. Moriguchi, C. (2003). "Implicit Contracts, the Great Depression, and Institutional Change: A Comparative Analysis of U.S. and Japanese Employment Relations, 1920–1940." *JEH*, 63(3), 625–665.
   Link

5. Perkins, D. & Tang, J.P. (2017). "East Asian Industrial Pioneers: Japan, Korea, and Taiwan." In *The Spread of Modern Industry to the Periphery since 1871*.
   Link

X. Long-run Persistence & Economic Development

X. Long-run Persistence & Economic Development

1. Davis, D.R. & Weinstein, D.E. (2002). "Bones, Bombs, and Break Points: The Geography of Economic Activity." *AER*, 92(5), 1269–1289.
   Link
2. Moriguchi, C. (2003). "Implicit Contracts, the Great Depression, and Institutional Change." *JEH*, 63(3), 625–665.
   Link
3. Nakabayashi, M. (2014). "Imperialism and Fiscal Autonomy in Colonial Korea." In *Economic and Political Change in Asia under Globalization*.
   Link

X. Long-run Persistence (cont.)

4. Okazaki, T. (2023). "Regime Change and Elite Mobility: Evidence from the Meiji Restoration in Japan." *Working Paper*.
   Link
5. Okazaki, T. & Tang, J.P. (2021). "Banks, Credit Supply, and the Life Cycle of Firms: Theory and Evidence from Late Nineteenth Century Japan." *Working Paper*.
   Link
6. Braguinsky, S. & Hounshell, D.A. (2016). "History and Nanoeconomics in Strategy and Industry Evolution Research." In *The Oxford Handbook of Strategy*.
   Link

Thank You

Questions & Discussion

Contact: shumingyu@foxmail.com